

Artwork/ornaments/mirrors

Stores like Goodwill are perfect hiding places for gems like these. There was a story about a woman who found an old painting at Goodwill, got it valued, and it was worth over \$1 million. That's not the point though. Most of the time you can pick up beautiful framed works of art, often original, and much cheaper than in department stores. The same goes for figurines, mirrors, and other home embellishments. Buy them used; no one will even know. — **Paul Michael**



Easiest Way to Save 3 Months' Salary

Want an easy way to save three months' salary? Don't buy a diamond engagement ring. If your fiancée, friends, and family scream hellfire, calmly explain:

It's just marketing. The whole "A Diamond Is Forever" and the idea of

a diamond engagement ring is not an ancient tradition to be revered and followed. It is Sprite's "Obey Your Thirst." It is Nike's "Just Do It." It is Gary Dahl's "Pet Rock." Not only did the diamond importers understand it had to control supply (buying up and closing down any diamond mine discovered); also they had to control demand. They had to make it sentimental. And Americans were the perfect suckers. They targeted the U.S. specifically for our marketability. This campaign is less than 80 years old yet has become so ingrained in our culture that the diamond engagement ring has become the ultimate symbol of *how much* the relationship, the girl, and love itself is worth.

Diamonds aren't rare. Fine, using marketing tactics can't be blamed since that's part of the game of capitalism. But another part of the game is competition. It's all well and good if marketers can convince consumers to buy them instead of the competition based on a nice slogan, but the competition should be there to protect the consumer. All gems are valued based on their rarity (as are most things in life). But diamonds are abundant. One company has a huge vault where they keep most of the world's supply of diamonds. If it ever got released into the market, diamonds would be